When I contacted Stephen Alter for a quick interview regarding his latest book, the prolific Mussoorie-based writer was at an Aerocity hotel in Delhi, having just landed from Goa—where he also lives—and off to Dibrugarh and onwards to several wildlife sanctuaries in eastern Assam. In his mid-60s, and writing for well over four decades, Alter is showing no signs of slowing down.

His first book, published in 1978, was *Neglected Lives*. In that novel, the young protagonist, Lionel Carmichael, had fled to the hill station of Debrakot after a forbidden love affair in Lucknow. Alter's latest, *Death in Shambles: A Hill Station Mystery*, fast forwards four and a half decades, with Lionel returning to Debrakot to settle there, having just retired from the Indian Police Service. To be plainer, he was forced to resign six months before his scheduled retirement, the aftermath of breaking a prominent politician's nose.

"Honestly, I never imagined I would write a sequel to *Neglected Lives*, but two or three years ago, when I started to think about trying my hand at a murder mystery, it struck me that the fictional hill station of Debrakot, which I invented 45 years ago, would be a good setting for the story," says Alter. "Then I thought, why not bring back the main character, Lionel, as a retired police officer? Revisiting the town was interesting, though *Death in Shambles* is quite different from my first book and stands on its own."

The action centres around the rundown Shambala Villa (hence, Shambles), where self-styled godman Reuben Sabharwal conducts retreats for his devotees—that is, until he is murdered. His body, violently stabbed and slouched on the stove, is discovered by the maid, next to that of a hanging woman. Nothing is as it seems, however, as we discover.

Inspector Thapliyal's request to investigate the crime informally is a welcome respite for the divorced Lionel who goes about solving the crime in his methodical, strait-laced way. He is a delightful Luddite armed with a cheap Chinese mobile phone and a landline, both of which barely work. "When I first wrote about Lionel, in 1976, I was still in college, about his age. For me, and I hope for my readers, it's now much more interesting to jump forward to the present, when both my character and I have aged and, perhaps, grown a little wiser or less foolish," says Alter.

Like many of us, Alter grew up on a nourishing diet of Arthur Conan Doyles's Sherlock Holmes stories. More recently, he has been inspired by Irish novelist Adrian McKinty, creator of the Sean Duffy series of crime novels. Residing in misty Mussoorie may have further honed his crime-writing skills. "Hill stations are full of atmosphere and nostalgia, even though most of them have changed dramatically in my lifetime," says Alter. "But there is still something that suggests loneliness and enigmatic lore. Debrakot, the town in my book, is also full of eccentric characters that make us wonder who they are and what they're up to—possibly no good!"

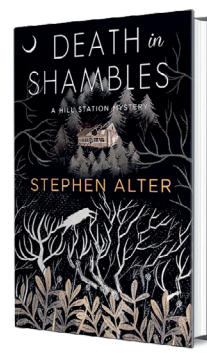
On a more serious note, in 2008, Alter and his wife Ameeta were brutally attacked by intruders in their Mussoorie home and left for dead. Luckily, the couple survived. The assault is described in *Becoming a Mountain*, a book Alter wrote to deal with the trauma. The gore in *Death in Shambles*, including Lionel being ambushed towards the end, seems eerily on point. "Novels emerge out of a combination of memory and imagination. Yes, perhaps I drew upon my experience of being attacked and stabbed, but fortunately I was luckier than the victims in my book and survived," says Alter.

Alter has also dabbled in the related genre of espionage with his Colonel Afridi series, which comprises *Birdwatching*, *The Rataban Betrayal* and *Guldaar* so far. "Three is a nice number. I'm not sure I'll write any more in that series, but...who knows?"

On the personal front, Alter and his wife mostly divide their time between Mussoorie and Goa, but with their son in Colorado and daughter now in France, they have "all four legs in different places". While the Mussoorie Mountain Festival that Alter founded is no more ("I decided to stop after 10 years of it, before it became a chore"), Alter keeps busy with his writing ("My wife complains that all I do is write"), but also enjoys trekking, birdwatching and, occasionally, cooking.

*Death in Shambles* is not a whodunit in the classic sense—the twists and turns are far gentler. There's mystery and menace, ritual and romance, an interesting cast of characters, a sense of place—and an endearingly understated quality to the writing. So, are we going to see more Lionel Carmichael books now? "Sure. I would enjoy giving him another murder to solve. He's obviously good at it," says Alter. ■

***Amit Dixit***




**DEATH IN SHAMBLES**
**A Hill Station Mystery**
*by Stephen Alter*
ALEPH
**₹599; 216** pages